SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Your Google Business Profile

Set it up properly, keep it accurate, and stay within the rules

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Your Google Business Profile — Set it up properly, keep it accurate, and stay within the rules

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This guide is independent and is not affiliated with, sponsored by, or endorsed by Google. Google sets the rules for Business Profiles and changes its features and guidelines often, so check Google Business Profile Help for the current version before you act.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Contents

Before you start

Understanding and setting up your profile

- What a Business Profile is, and is not
- Getting ready
- Verification

Address, name and categories

- Storefront or service-area business
- Your business name
- Choosing categories

Filling in your profile

- Your description and common questions
- Hours and holiday hours
- Services, products, attributes and links
- Serving customers in English and French

Photos, posts and reviews

- Photos and posts
- Reviews

Keeping it accurate and safe

- Keep your details the same everywhere
- Who has access, and unwanted changes
- A 20-minute monthly routine

Templates and worksheets

- Profile information worksheet
- Description drafts
- Photo shot list
- Post ideas calendar
- Review request message
- Monthly maintenance checklist

Checklist

Where to learn more

Before you start

A Google Business Profile is the free listing that can show your business name, hours, phone number, photos and reviews when someone looks you up on Google Search or Google Maps. This guide walks you through setting one up properly and then keeping it accurate with a short monthly routine.

It is written for Canadian small-business owners: sole proprietors and small teams such as cleaners, contractors, salons, tutors, bookkeepers, food trucks and small shops. If you can fill in a form and take a photo with your phone, you can do everything in here. You will learn how to choose between showing your address and listing a service area, name and categorize your business the way Google's guidelines expect, get through verification without creating duplicate listings, write a clear description, set holiday hours, add useful photos, ask for reviews fairly, and protect the profile from unwanted changes.

What this guide is not. This is general information, not legal or marketing advice, and it is not an official Google document. The author is not connected to Google in any way. Google decides what appears in search results, what its guidelines say, and which features exist, and those things change.

For that reason, this guide does not give exact menu paths or button names. Google moves things around in its screens, so a "tap here, then here" list would soon be out of date. Instead, the guide tells you what to look for and why. When your screen does not match what you read here, trust the screen and check **Google Business Profile Help** (support.google.com/business) for the current steps.

> NOTE
>
> At the time of writing, a Google Business Profile is free. If anyone calls or emails saying you must pay Google to keep or "verify" your listing, be cautious, and check with Google Business Profile Help before you pay anyone.

How to use the worksheets. The templates chapter near the end holds a profile information worksheet, three sample descriptions, a photo shot list, a year of post ideas, a review request message, and a monthly maintenance checklist. Fill in the profile worksheet before you sit down at the computer. It turns setup into typing instead of hunting for details.

Understanding and setting up your profile

What a Business Profile is, and is not

Your Business Profile is Google's record of your business. Once it is set up and verified, you can manage what it says: your name, hours, contact details, the area you serve, photos, a description, and more. People can find it when they search for your business by name, and it can also appear when someone searches for the kind of thing you do near where they are.

It is not a website, and it is not an ad. You do not pay for it, and you do not control where it shows up. Think of it as a public business card that Google keeps on file, plus a place where customers can leave reviews.

It also does not replace your own website, if you have one. Your website is the place you fully control: your full service list, your policies, your prices, your booking page. Your profile points people there and gives them the quick facts. Keep the two consistent, and when you have more to say than a profile has room for, say it on your website.

How Google says local results work. Google says its local results are based mainly on three things:

- **Relevance:** how well a profile matches what someone searched for.
- **Distance:** how far the business is from the searcher, or from the location in their search.
- **Prominence:** how well known the business is, which Google says draws on information from across the web.

That is Google's own framing, and it is worth reading in full on Google Business Profile Help. Notice what it means for you. You cannot change your distance from a customer. You can make your profile complete and accurate, so Google has a clear picture of what you do and where, and you can run a good business that people talk about. Beyond that, the outcome is up to Google.

A complete, accurate profile still matters. It gives people the basics without hunting: are you open, where are you, what do you do, how do they reach you. That makes it easier for the right customers to find and contact you, even though nothing about the result is promised.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> No one can promise you a top spot on Google Maps. If a company promises rankings, claims a “special relationship” with Google, or asks for your account password, walk away. Google Business Profile Help has guidance on working with marketing companies and other third parties that is worth reading first.

Features come and go. Google adds, changes and removes Business Profile features. Two examples: Google ended Business Profile websites (the simple free sites built from profiles) in 2024, and it ended Business Profile chat the same year. If an older article tells you to set up either one, skip that part.

Expect more changes. Throughout this guide you will see phrases like “if your profile offers” or “where available”. That is deliberate. Check the current options in your own profile and in Google Business Profile Help.

Getting ready

Setting up goes faster when everything is in front of you. Use the **Profile information worksheet** in the templates chapter. At a minimum, have your business name exactly as it appears on your signage and invoices; your street address if customers come to you, or the areas you serve if you go to them; the phone number you actually answer; your website, if you have one; your regular and seasonal hours; a list of your main services or products; and a few good photos.

You manage a Business Profile through a Google account, and whoever controls that account controls the profile. Many owners find it useful to use an account dedicated to the business, with an email address the business owns. Whatever you choose, make sure it is an account **you** control, not one belonging to an employee, a relative who helps out, or the person who built your website. Turn on two-step verification and keep the recovery details up to date.

Claim, create, or fix duplicates. Before you create anything, search for your business on Google Search and Google Maps. Try your business name, your name plus your town, and your phone number. You may find:

- **Nothing.** You will create a new profile.
- **A profile no one manages.** Google may have created a listing from public information, or a customer may have added you. Claim it rather than start over; look for an option on the listing about owning or managing this business.

- **A profile someone else manages.** A former employee, a previous owner or a marketing company may control it. Google Business Profile Help explains how to request access from the current owner. Follow that process rather than creating a second listing to get around it.

A duplicate is a second profile for the same business at the same place. Duplicates confuse customers (which phone number is right?), can split your reviews between listings, and can cause trouble during verification. Google's guidelines do not allow them. They can appear when a business moves or rebrands, or when someone sets up a new listing after losing access to the old one. If you find one, Google Business Profile Help explains how to report or remove it.

If you have moved, update the address on your existing profile rather than creating a new one, and be ready for Google to ask you to verify again. If a business has closed for good, Google Business Profile Help explains how to mark it closed so customers are not sent to an empty storefront.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a two-person cleaning business in Truro called Harbourline Cleaning. You search your phone number and find two listings: one you set up years ago with an old email address you can no longer get into, and one Google created from an online directory. Rather than make a third, you use Google's process to recover the account or request access to the first listing, then report the second as a duplicate.

Verification

Verification is how Google checks that you are the real business and entitled to manage the profile. Until a profile is verified, it is not fully public and you cannot manage all of it. It also protects you, because it makes it harder for someone else to take over your listing.

Google decides which verification methods to offer you; you do not pick from a full menu. Depending on your business type, location, history and other things Google considers, you might be offered a **video** recording, a **phone call or text** with a code, an **email**, a **postcard by mail**, or another method. Google Business Profile Help explains what each one requires.

If you are asked for a video, read Google's current requirements before you press record; they spell out what the recording needs to show. The aim is to show that you are a real business at a real place and that you manage it, for example your signage or street, your equipment or branded vehicle, and something only the business can access. Plan the shot, use good light, and do not show customer information.

Verification can take time and sometimes needs more than one attempt. While you wait, **do not create a new profile** because the first one seems stuck, and do not keep editing your name, address or category unless Google asks you to. Note what you submitted and when, and keep a folder of things that show your business is real, such as your business registration, a utility bill or lease in the business name, photos of your signage or lettered vehicle, and a recent invoice. You may need them if Google asks for more proof later. If verification fails, read the reason Google gives, fix the issue, and try again or contact support through Google Business Profile Help.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a landscaping business in Bridgewater and Google offers you video verification. Before recording, you read Google's current instructions and plan the route: start at your truck with the business name on the door, show your trailer and equipment, then show something only the business has, such as your work order book or the keys to the equipment lock. You film it in one take in daylight, keep customer names out of the frame, and submit it. Then you wait, without touching the profile, until Google replies.

WATCH OUT

Google does not need your account password to verify you, and neither does a legitimate helper. To let someone help, add them to your profile with their own access, as explained in the chapter on keeping your profile accurate and safe.

KEY POINTS

- A Business Profile is a free listing that can appear in Google Search and Maps. Nobody can promise you rankings.
- Google says local results are based mainly on relevance, distance and prominence.
- Use a Google account the business controls, and claim an existing listing before you create one.
- Deal with duplicates through Google's process, not by adding another profile.
- Google chooses which verification methods to offer. Be patient and do not start over.

Address, name and categories

These three settings shape how Google understands your business. Get them right at the start, because changing them later may lead Google to ask you to verify again.

Storefront or service-area business

Google treats businesses in two broad ways, and some are both:

- **Customers come to you.** A salon, shop, café, clinic, or an office where clients visit. Your profile shows your address so people can find you.
- **You go to customers.** A cleaner, plumber, mobile dog groomer or landscaper. Google calls this a **service-area business**. You can hide your address and list the area you serve instead.
- **Both.** A bakery that also delivers, or a repair shop that also does house calls. You can show your address and list a service area.

Choose the setup that matches how customers actually deal with you. Google's guidelines call for a real address, and they have specific rules about mailboxes, shared spaces and virtual offices. Read the current guidelines before you use any address that is not a place where you actually work.

When you list your service area, name the towns, cities or regions you really serve. Listing every community in the province to look bigger does not match how you work.

Running a business from home. If you work from home and travel to customers, a service-area profile lets you keep your home address off the public listing. You may still need to give Google your address during setup or verification; hiding it means the public does not see it.

If clients come to your home (a home hair studio, say, or a tutor who teaches at the kitchen table), think carefully. A public home address has privacy and safety costs, and the setup has to match what actually happens. Read Google's guidelines on which setup fits, and if a public home address is not something you are comfortable with, consider whether serving clients at their place, online, or in a separate workspace would suit you better.

Your business name

Google's guidelines say to use your real-world business name: the name you use consistently on your signage, vehicles, invoices, website and stationery. Adding keywords, town names or slogans to the name is called **keyword stuffing**, and it is against Google's guidelines.

Written as	Within the guidelines?
Harbourline Cleaning	Yes, if that is the real name
Harbourline Cleaning – Best House Cleaners Truro	No, keywords and a claim added
Harbourline Cleaning Truro NS Cheap Rates	No, location and keywords added

If your registered legal name differs from the name customers know you by, use the name you actually trade under, consistently. Your description, services and service area are the places to say what you do and where.

Choosing categories

Categories tell Google what kind of business you are. You pick from Google's list rather than typing your own. You choose one main category and, in many cases, can add more.

- Pick the main category that describes **what you are**, not everything you do. A salon is a hair salon even if it also sells shampoo.
- Be specific where an accurate specific option exists. "House cleaning service" says more than a broad option.
- Add other categories only for real, substantial parts of the business. A few accurate categories are clearer than a long list of loose fits.

If there is no exact match, choose the closest accurate option and fill in the detail in your description. Look at your categories again once a year, or whenever you add or drop a major service.

KEY POINTS

- Show your address if customers come to you. Hide it and list a service area if you go to them.
- Use your real-world name with no added keywords, towns or slogans.
- Choose one accurate main category, and add others only if they are true.

Filling in your profile

Once you can manage your profile, fill in every section that applies. Each accurate detail answers a customer's question before they have to ask it.

Your description and common questions

The description is a short paragraph, in your own words, about what you do. Google sets a character limit, so check how much space you have. Google also has content rules for descriptions, covering things like links, promotions and misleading claims. Read them before you publish.

A good description answers four questions in plain language: **what** you do, **who** it is for, **where** you are or serve, and **what people should know** (how booking works, languages you serve in, anything that makes you easier to deal with). Write it the way you would explain your business to a neighbour, and put the most important information in the first sentence or two, since people may see only the start before tapping to read more. The templates chapter has three made-up examples you can adapt.

Answering common questions up front. Think about the questions you hear most often. Do you serve my area? Do you take e-transfer? Is there parking? Do I need an appointment? Google has changed how questions and answers are handled on profiles over the years, so do not rely on any one feature. Put the biggest answers (area, booking, languages) in your description, use attributes and service details where your profile offers them, and keep a short questions section on your website if you have one.

Hours and holiday hours

Set your regular hours accurately. If you work by appointment only, check what options your profile offers for showing that, and say so in your description.

Then set **special hours** (often called holiday hours) for days when you will be closed or open different hours. Some days, like Canada Day and Christmas Day, are observed across the country. Others depend on where you are, and which days are statutory holidays varies by province and territory. Your own closures, such as a vacation or a snow day, matter too.

At the start of each year, mark every day you expect to close or change hours, and enter special hours for the ones coming up. The monthly routine in this guide reminds you to check the next six weeks.

> **NOTE**
>
> If you have employees, which holidays you must give them and how you pay for them is set by your province's employment standards rules, not by Google. Check your province's employment standards website.

Services, products, attributes and links

Depending on your category, your profile may let you list **services** (the specific jobs you do), **products** (items you sell, with photos), and **attributes** (short facts such as accessibility features, payment options, or whether you serve customers online). Fill these in where they are accurate. Only select attributes that are true; if your entrance has steps, do not tick a wheelchair-accessible box. If you list prices, keep them current or describe them as a starting point.

Phone, website and booking links. Use a phone number someone answers during the hours you list, and use the same number everywhere. Add your website if you have one. If you take bookings online, your profile may let you add a booking or appointment link, or connect with a booking provider, depending on your category and what Google currently supports. Whatever you add, test it yourself from a phone.

Serving customers in English and French

If you serve customers in both official languages, or in another language, say so. Your profile has one description, so one approach is to write the main text in the language you use with the bulk of your customers and add a short line in the other.

Use your real-world business name. If your signs show a bilingual name, use that name as it appears; do not create separate profiles for each language. Make sure your website, booking page and phone greeting match what you promise. If you operate in Quebec, provincial language rules apply to things like commercial signage and documents; check the Quebec government's guidance or ask a professional.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Write a plain description that says what, who, where, and how to book.
> - Set special hours for holidays and closures. Holidays vary by province.
> - Add services, products and attributes only where accurate, and test every link.

Photos, posts and reviews

Photos and posts

Photos show customers what to expect: your storefront before they arrive, the quality of your finished work, or the person who will show up at their door. Use pictures of your actual business, work and team. Stock photos, heavily filtered images, or photos of someone else's work can mislead customers and break Google's content policies.

Use the **Photo shot list** in the templates chapter. In general, aim for a mix of:

- **Finding you:** the outside of your building from the street, your entrance and sign, parking. For service-area businesses, your branded vehicle or equipment.
- **Inside:** your shop floor, waiting area, counter or workshop.
- **Your work:** finished jobs, before-and-after pairs, products on the shelf.
- **Your people:** you and your team at work, with their permission.
- **Logo and cover:** a clean logo file and one strong photo that represents the business.

A recent phone is enough. Shoot in daylight or good, even light, wipe the lens, tidy the space, and take several shots so you can keep the best. Small fixes to brightness are fine; changing what things look like is not.

Privacy and permission. Ask before you photograph customers, their homes or their property, and leave out anything that identifies them (house numbers, licence plates, faces, mail on the counter) unless they have clearly agreed. Get permission from staff too. Privacy law applies to personal information you collect in your business; when in doubt, leave people out of the shot.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a mobile dog-grooming van in Kelowna. Good photos might include the outside of your van with its logo, the clean grooming table inside, a few freshly groomed dogs (with their owners' permission), and you at work. A photo of a spotless salon you found online would not be your business, so it does not belong on your profile.

Posts and updates. Your profile may let you publish short **posts**: a photo and a few lines about news, an event, a seasonal service or an offer. Posts are optional, but they are a simple way to share timely information. Good topics are practical: seasonal services ("Spring yard cleanups are now booking"), changes in hours, a new service, an event you will be at, or a recent project with a photo.

Keep posts accurate. If you share an offer, say clearly what it is and when it ends, and honour it. Google has content policies for posts, so read them before you start. The **Post ideas calendar** in the templates chapter gives a year of seasonal prompts.

> **TIP**
>
> You do not need to post every day. One useful post a month, timed with your season, is a reasonable rhythm for a small business.

Reviews

Reviews are a large topic, and another guide in this series covers them in depth. Here are the basics as they relate to your profile.

Ask everyone, the same way. Google's guidelines do not allow **review gating**: asking only the customers you think are happy, or screening people first and sending only satisfied ones to Google. The fair approach is simple. Ask every customer, or a consistent group (for example, everyone after a finished job), the same way.

At the time of writing, Google gives profile owners a way to share a direct link for leaving a review. Look for it in your profile tools and put it in the review request message in the templates chapter. Good moments to ask are right after you finish a job, in your thank-you or invoice email, or on a small card left with the customer.

If you send review requests by email or text, keep in mind that Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL) applies to commercial electronic messages. Keep the request tied to the job you just did, leave promotions out of it, and get consent before you send marketing messages. Ask a lawyer if you are unsure.

No incentives, no fake reviews. Google does not allow incentives for reviews: no discounts, draws, gifts or freebies in exchange for a review, even an honest one. Canada's Competition Bureau has also warned that fake reviews, reviews by owners or employees posing as customers, and hiding negative reviews can be misleading under the Competition Act. Do not write reviews for your own business, ask staff or family to post them, or buy them.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Breaking Google's review rules can lead to reviews being removed or the profile being suspended, and misleading reviews can raise issues under the Competition Act. This is general information, not legal advice. If you are unsure whether something is allowed, check Google's policies and the Competition Bureau's guidance first.

Replying, and what you cannot do. As the owner, you can reply publicly to reviews. Thank people for positive reviews and keep it short. For negative reviews, stay calm, acknowledge the concern, and invite the person to contact you directly. Do not argue in public, and **never** include personal information about the customer, such as their address or details of the job. A public reply is public, and privacy law applies to customer information.

EXAMPLE

Say a customer of your Moncton bookkeeping practice leaves a one-star review saying you missed a deadline. A calm reply might read: “Thank you for the feedback. We are sorry the timing did not work out. We would like to understand what happened and put it right. Please call us at the office so we can talk it through.” It does not mention their business, their file or any dates, and it does not argue.

You cannot delete reviews. You can report reviews that break Google’s policies, such as spam or fake reviews, and Google decides whether to remove them. If a review is threatening, defamatory, or reveals private information, report it and consider talking to a lawyer. Never threaten a reviewer.

Try to reply within a few days, and if a reviewer writes in French or another language you work in, reply in that language. Adding review replies to your monthly routine keeps them from piling up.

KEY POINTS

- Use real photos of your own business, work and team, with permission from the people in them.
- Posts are optional. Keep them practical, accurate and seasonal.
- Ask every customer for a review the same way. No gating, no incentives, no fake reviews.
- Reply briefly and politely, never share customer details, and report reviews that break Google’s policies.

Keeping it accurate and safe

Keep your details the same everywhere

Your business information lives in more places than your Google profile: your website, social media pages, online directories, your invoices, your van. When these match, customers and Google get one clear story.

Use the profile worksheet as your master record of name, address or service area, phone, website and hours. Update your website first, since you fully control it, then your social media pages and any directories you are listed in. Now and then, search your business name and old phone number to find stray listings. A few accurate listings are better than many outdated ones.

Who has access, and unwanted changes

Google lets you add other people to your profile with different levels of access. In broad terms, **owners** can do everything, including adding and removing people, while **managers** handle day-to-day edits with fewer powers. Check Google Business Profile Help for the current roles.

Keep yourself, or the business's own account, as the main owner. Do not hand primary ownership to an employee, agency or web developer. Give each helper their own access at the lowest level they need, rather than sharing a login, and remove people promptly when they leave.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a small hair studio in Saskatoon and your nephew set up your profile from his own Google account years ago. Ask him to add your business account as an owner, confirm you can get in, then have him transfer primary ownership to you.

Suggested edits. Members of the public can suggest changes to a business's information, and Google may update details using other sources. A suggestion can be helpful, but it can also be wrong, and occasionally it is deliberate mischief, such as marking a business as closed. Check your profile regularly as a customer would see it, not just in the management screen. Keep your notification email current and read Google's notices. If a wrong change appears, correct it, and use Google's support options if it keeps coming back.

Staying within the guidelines. Google can restrict or suspend a profile that breaks its guidelines. A suspended profile may disappear from public view, or you may lose the ability to manage it. Things the guidelines prohibit include keywords in the business name, a fake address or one where you do not operate, duplicate profiles, fake or incentivized reviews, review gating, and categories that do not describe the business.

Large changes made all at once, such as a new name, address and category on the same day, may also lead Google to re-check the profile. Make major changes one at a time where you can, and keep proof such as signage photos and registration papers handy. If your profile is suspended, read Google's explanation, fix the issue honestly, and use the appeal process in Google Business Profile Help. Do not create a new profile to replace a suspended one.

A 20-minute monthly routine

Pick a fixed day, such as the first Monday of the month, and put it in your calendar. The times below are a suggested budget only.

Task	Suggested time
View your profile on your phone, as a customer would	3 minutes
Check name, hours, phone, website and area for errors	3 minutes
Set special hours for the next six weeks	3 minutes
Read new reviews and reply	5 minutes
Add two or three photos of recent work	3 minutes
Publish one post (optional)	3 minutes

Every few months, also review who has access, reread your description and services, search for duplicates and outdated listings elsewhere, and glance at the basic performance information Google shows you for anything unexpected, such as a drop in calls that might point to a wrong phone number. Keep a short log of the date and what you changed.

KEY POINTS

- Keep your name, address, phone, website and hours identical everywhere.
- Stay the main owner. Give others their own, limited access.
- Book about 20 minutes a month to check, update, reply and add photos.

Templates and worksheets

Copy these into a notebook, a document or a spreadsheet. Replace everything in square brackets.

Profile information worksheet

WORKSHEET

Business name (exactly as on signage and invoices): _____

Customers come to me, I go to them, or both: _____

Street address (if customers visit): _____

Show address publicly? Yes / No

Service area (places I really serve): _____

Main category: _____

Other accurate categories: _____

Phone number customers should use: _____

Website and booking link: _____

Regular hours: _____

Seasonal hours: _____

Languages I serve customers in: _____

Main services or products: _____

Payment methods and accessibility details: _____

Google account that owns the profile: _____

Other people with access, and their level: _____

Description drafts

These three businesses are made up. Use them as models, write your own in your own words, and check the current character limit.

EXAMPLE

Harbourline Cleaning (service area, Truro, Nova Scotia)

Harbourline Cleaning is a two-person team providing regular and one-time house cleaning for homes in Truro, Bible Hill and nearby communities. We handle weekly and biweekly cleans, move-in and move-out cleans, and spring cleaning. We bring our own supplies and can use yours if you prefer. Book by phone or through our website; we confirm every visit the day before.

EXAMPLE

Birch Street Hair Studio (storefront, Saskatoon, Saskatchewan)

Birch Street Hair Studio is a small, appointment-based salon offering cuts, colour and styling for adults and children. We have two stylists and a quiet, relaxed space. There is free street parking out front, and our entrance is at ground level. Walk-ins are welcome when a chair is free, but booking ahead is the easiest way to get the time you want.

EXAMPLE

Comptabilité Petitcodiac Bookkeeping (service area, Moncton, New Brunswick)

Comptabilité Petitcodiac Bookkeeping provides monthly bookkeeping, payroll support and year-end preparation for small businesses in Moncton, Dieppe and Riverview. We work on-site or remotely and explain things in plain language. Service offert en français et en anglais. Book a free 20-minute call through our website to see whether we are a good fit.

The third example uses a bilingual name because, in this made-up case, that is the name on the sign and invoices. Do not add a second language to your name on Google unless it is part of your real-world name.

Photo shot list

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Outside of the building from the street, in daylight
- [ ] Entrance and sign, close enough to read; parking
- [ ] Branded vehicle or equipment (service-area businesses)
- [ ] Inside: main room, counter, waiting area or workshop
- [ ] Three to five examples of finished work
- [ ] Before-and-after pair (with the customer's permission)
- [ ] Products on display, if you sell products
- [ ] You and your team at work (with their permission)
- [ ] Logo file and one strong cover photo

Post ideas calendar

Adjust to your season, trade and province. Every month, also check whether you need special hours.

Month	Post idea
January	Hours for the new year; winter services
February	A recent job with a photo; how to book
March	Spring services opening up; a common question answered
April	Before-and-after photos; a seasonal tip
May	Long weekend hours; a new service or product
June	Summer hours; an event or market you will be at
July	Canada Day hours; a team photo
August	Fall booking; recent work
September	Fall services; Labour Day hours
October	Thanksgiving hours; winter preparation services
November	Holiday-season hours; gift cards if you sell them
December	Holiday closures; a thank-you to customers

Review request message

TEMPLATE

Subject: Thank you from [Business name]

Hi [Customer first name],

Thank you for choosing [Business name] for [short description of the job]. It was good to work with you.

If you have a minute, we would appreciate an honest review on Google. It helps other people in [town or area] know what to expect from us.

[Your review link]

If anything was not right, please reply to this email or call [phone number] so we can fix it.

Thanks again, [Your name], [Business name]

Send the same message to every customer, not only the ones you think are happy, and do not offer anything in exchange for a review.

Monthly maintenance checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Viewed my profile on my phone as a customer would
- [ ] Name, phone, website, address or service area all correct
- [ ] No unwanted changes or wrong suggested edits
- [ ] Special hours set for holidays and closures in the next six weeks
- [ ] New reviews read and replied to
- [ ] Two or three new photos added; one post published (optional)
- [ ] Booking and website links tested
- [ ] Log updated with today’s date and what changed

Checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Filled in the profile information worksheet
- [ ] Chose a Google account the business controls; two-step verification on
- [ ] Searched Google Search and Maps for an existing listing and duplicates
- [ ] Claimed the existing profile or created one new profile
- [ ] Chose storefront, service area, or both, to match how I serve customers
- [ ] Used my real-world business name with no added keywords
- [ ] Picked one accurate main category and only true additional ones
- [ ] Completed verification without creating a duplicate
- [ ] Wrote a plain description: what, who, where, how to book
- [ ] Set regular hours and special hours for upcoming holidays
- [ ] Added accurate services, products and attributes
- [ ] Added and tested phone, website and booking links
- [ ] Mentioned languages I serve in, if more than one
- [ ] Uploaded real photos from the shot list
- [ ] Set up a review request message that goes to every customer
- [ ] Replied to existing reviews politely, with no personal details
- [ ] Made my details match on my website and other listings
- [ ] Checked who has access; I am the main owner
- [ ] Booked a monthly 20-minute maintenance time in my calendar

Where to learn more

- **Google Business Profile Help** (support.google.com/business). Current guidelines for representing your business, verification steps, roles and access, review policies, and how to appeal a suspension. When this guide and Google's Help pages differ, Google's pages are the current word.
- **Competition Bureau Canada** (competition-bureau.canada.ca). Guidance on misleading advertising and fake or misleading reviews.
- **Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada** (priv.gc.ca). Guidance for businesses on handling customer personal information. Alberta, British Columbia and Quebec have their own private-sector privacy laws.
- **Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL)**. Information for businesses is on the Government of Canada website (canada.ca). Useful if you send review requests or updates by email or text.
- **Your province's consumer protection office**, if you run offers or promotions in posts and want to understand the rules where you are.
- **Your province's employment standards office.** If you have staff, check which holidays and pay rules apply. In Nova Scotia, see novascotia.ca.

When to talk to a professional:

- **A lawyer**, if a review is defamatory or threatening, if you receive a legal demand about your listing, or if you are unsure whether a promotion or review practice is allowed.
- **A marketing or web professional**, if you want help with photos, your website or your listings. Choose someone who explains what they will do, gives you your own access rather than taking yours, and does not promise rankings.
- **Google support**, through Google Business Profile Help, for verification problems, suspensions, ownership disputes and duplicate listings.

Your Business Profile is a small piece of your business, but it is often the first thing a new customer sees. Keep it honest, keep it current, and give it 20 minutes a month.